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Culture (OWC): [Azande \(F007\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

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Place Coverage

Sudan, Democratic Republic of the Congo, and Central African Republic

Section Title(S): REGULATION OF PUBLIC LIFE

The system of administration was always the same. The chiefs of the conquered people would often be regarded as deputy chiefs and their sons educated at the court of their lord, who in his rule scarcely differentiated between his fellow countrymen and his foreign subjects; a condition of prosperity ensued, and more and more Azande spread into the occupied area. The mutual cohesion of these kingdoms depended mainly on the character of the paramount lord, for there was always a tendency for the brother or son of the chief who acted as provincial governor to break away, while at the death of the ruler the country was plunged into civil war until one of his sons established himself as successor.

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A chief must be succeeded by a son or brother, but apart from this there is no precise rule of succession and a younger son may be chosen in preference to his elder brother if he be considered more intelligent. The chief's deputy, *bakumba*, is appointed by the district, not the paramount chief, and is not a Vongara. Although the boundaries of his territory are but roughly defined there is no doubt as to the deputy to whom each man is subject, for the relationship is personal and not territorial.

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There is no familiarity between a paramount chief and his sons and younger brothers, who fear their father greatly and are subjected to severe discipline. They may lord it over their provinces, but they have to show themselves completely subordinate to their suzerain. They seldom come near him unless specially summoned or to pay formal visits, and then they will approach him in a crouching position, just as their own subjects approach them. Between a chief and his deputies there is not the same strain; a chief is often seen joking with his old Zande deputies, but to his own sons he maintains an unrelaxed expression of severity, for they alone are possible rivals, since before the changes brought about by European administration it was impossible for any

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man not a Vongara to become a chief. The greatest power to which a commoner could attain was to hold an important governorship, with a small court of his own modelled on that of his chief.

The chief's deputy (*bakumba*) superintends the carrying out of the chief's orders, sees to the collection of dues, to supplying labourers for the chief's estate and meat for his household, to the apprehension of criminals, the calling out of a district for war, the clearing of paths, the arrangements of religious ceremonies. He also frequently visits the court to report to his lord upon the state of his district and the loyalty of his subjects.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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